



EGYPT

Capital city: Cairo
Area: 386,660 sq miles (1001,450 sq km)
Population: 71,900,000
Official language: Arabic
Major religions: Muslim 94%, other 6%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Egyptian pound
Adult literacy rate: 56%
Life expectancy: 69 years
People per doctor: 625
Televisions: 122 per 1,000 people

The Suez Canal is used by more than 20,000 ships every year.

SUEZ CANAL

The Suez Canal runs from the Red Sea to the Mediterranean Sea. It is the one of the world's largest and most important artificial waterways, providing a shortcut from Europe to India and East Asia. The canal was built with French and British help and was completed in 1869. It has since been made deeper and wider to allow for the increasing size of ships and tankers. In 1956 the canal came under Egyptian control. Today, the tolls taken from the ships that use the canal are an important source of income for the Egyptian government.



The Sphinx, built of soft sandstone, has the body of a lion and the head of a man.

ANCIENT SITES

Egypt is littered with ancient monuments. Every year, millions of tourists flock to Egypt to see the pyramids and other sites, or to take a boat trip on the Nile River. The pyramids, built more than 4,000 years ago as tombs for the pharaohs, are one of the seven wonders of the ancient world and the only one to survive.

EGYPT

IT IS SAID THAT EGYPT is the gift of the Nile River. The site of one of the world's first great civilizations, Egypt grew up under the rule of the pharaohs along the banks of the Nile more than 5,000 years ago. Most of the country is dry, sandy desert with a narrow, fertile strip that follows the river valley and widens into the delta. This is where the vast majority of Egypt's population lives. Most of the people are Arab and follow the Muslim faith. The economy is dominated by farming, oil, tourism, income from ships passing through the Suez Canal, and money earned by Egyptians working abroad.



Route before Suez Canal
Route after Suez was built

The Suez Canal offered a shortcut from Europe to India and East Asia. Earlier, ships from Europe had sailed around Africa.



CAIRO

With a population of more than 15 million, Cairo is the largest city in Africa and one of the fastest growing. The city faces terrible housing problems. New arrivals often have to live in dirty, overcrowded slums. Some live among the graves of the City of the Dead, a huge cemetery on the outskirts of the city. People also live on the roofs of the many high-rise buildings in Cairo.



FUL MEDAMES

This Egyptian dish is made by boiling fava beans with onions, vegetables, and spices. This may be eaten with an egg for breakfast. A similar mixture is used to stuff *aysh* (flat bread), making sandwiches.



THE NILE RIVER
Some 99 percent of Egyptians live in the valley or delta of the Nile River. The river is Egypt's lifeline, providing water for farming, industry, and home use. When the Aswan High Dam was built on the Nile, it created the world's largest reservoir, Lake Nasser.

FARMING IN EGYPT

Many Egyptian farmers, or *felahin*, use traditional farming methods to grow cotton, wheat, rice, sugar, fruit, and vegetables. Egypt is the world's second largest producer of dates. Another important crop is *berseem*, a type of clover grown for animal feed. Egypt is also one of the world's biggest cotton growers. Many people are employed in the textile industry, spinning, weaving, and dyeing the fine-quality cotton to make clothes and other goods.

Cool and comfortable cotton tunics, called jellabas, are often worn by Egyptian men.



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